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Filipino family dynamics and culture may influence how traditional values like "*utang na loob*" (debt of gratitude) are understood across time. The purpose of the study is to understand the concept of *utang na loob* in the Southern Philippines from the perspective of working *panganays* (eldest children). The research investigated the narratives of the eldest child in the Filipino family regarding their experiences with *utang na loob*. It employed Murray's three levels of narrative analysis as a framework and elicited themes on personal, positional, and ideological levels. Results revealed personal experiences of early maturity and filial pressure, gratitude, and fulfillment, among others. The positional narratives complement the personal narratives as they describe their roles as second parents, financial providers, and decision-makers. Similarly, their ideological narratives revealed internalized familial obligations shaped by cultural expectations, empowered responsibility arising from adversity to provide family support, and increased hope in the capacity to cultivate a better future for one's family. Implications of the findings regarding community interventions to address difficulties in socioeconomic disparities, family responsibilities, and personal development are discussed.

KEYWORDS: family dynamics; narrative analysis; Sikolohiyang Pilipino; *utang na loob*; working *panganays*

1. INTRODUCTION

Families often establish bonds that value close family ties and solidarity rooted in the Asian characteristics of Filipinos, where harmony and interdependence are valued, creating a deeply felt relationship in families (Dy 2003). It comes as no surprise that Filipinos are ready to go far and beyond their own boundaries for the sake of closeness and devotion to their families. This results in extensive pressure on the eldest children to display qualities of being responsible, obedient, and stable. Most of the eldest children are perceived as the backbone of the sibling order, resulting in eldest children having a hard time saying no to their families when asked for favors (Case 2011). In the Philippines, it is a common practice for the eldest child to be the second parent to their siblings (Jumalon et al. 2023). In times of difficulties, the eldest children have often carried the burden of looking for means for the family's survival through financial assistance, emotional support, or physical presence.

The implications of expectations for one's children and the weight of being the eldest lie in the value of "*utang na loob*" or debt of gratitude owed to another person through expressions of deep respect and gratitude (Enriquez 1994). Reyes (2015) argues that *utang na loob* is the self-imposed obligation to give back the same kind of beauty-of-will a person has shown you. In a family setting, parents are responsible for childbearing and child-rearing, often sacrificing much of their time, effort, and resources. However, it is a common phenomenon among Filipinos that children are expected to possess *utang na loob* toward their parents through honoring the family obligations and giving back to their families.

Previous studies explored the experiences of eldest children in the context of Filipino values. However, they have not addressed how these experiences affect the eldest children throughout their lives. In this paper, we would like to address research gaps and gain extensive insights regarding the narratives of working *panganays* (eldest children) and their experiences of *utang na loob* in their families, which previous research has not delved into. Through an

analysis of these experiences, this study aims to re-evaluate the long-standing accounts of utang na loob in families, focusing on the present times.

FILIPINO FAMILY DYNAMICS

The Philippines, as an interdependent country, follows collectivist characteristics that emphasize others and social support, especially in decision-making (Broomhall, Phillips, and Wu 2020). Specifically, the Filipino family setting promotes high values of reciprocity, which observes extended kinship (Go 1993; Medina 2001; and Miralao 1997 cited in Tarroja 2010). In this context, the family is considered the primary unit of society. Many social behaviors are thereby geared toward maintaining harmony and unity within this structure.

The concept of utang na loob is fundamental to understanding Filipino family dynamics. This cultural value dictates that individuals are morally obligated to repay those who have provided them with significant help, particularly family members. This cultural expectation places a significant responsibility on children, especially the eldest, to contribute to the family's welfare, both emotionally and economically. This collective orientation shapes behaviors such as providing support for family members in times of need, including extending financial help and making personal sacrifices for the sake of family harmony (Dizon et al. 2024). These values are passed on intergenerationally, maintaining the stability and cohesion of Filipino families across different contexts.

In the present, the practice of utang na loob continues to hold its original intent for some families, but how it is introduced and the expectations placed on firstborns have significantly influenced its application within Filipino households. According to Baculi, Garapo, and Polvoriza (2022), the way this value is passed down shapes how it is practiced, particularly by the eldest children who often bear the weight of familial obligations tied to utang na loob.

UTANG NA LOOB IN SIKOLOHIYANG PILIPINO

“Sikolohiyang Pilipino” or “Filipino psychology” describes psychology that is derived from Filipino experience, thought, and orientation and is founded on the full usage of the Filipino language and culture (Rungduin et al. 2016). One of the most important Filipino values, utang na loob is essential to preserving interpersonal ties, especially in family systems. The concept originates from Sikolohiyang Pilipino, which emphasizes the moral need to return kindness. According to Rungduin et al. (2016), utang na loob is frequently defined by *pagtutumbas* (reciprocity) and *pagkilala* (acknowledgment) in which the beneficiary of a favor feels profoundly beholden even if the giver does not specifically request reimbursement. As recipients work to return acts of kindness, whether materially or by continuing to show kindness to others, this reciprocal relationship fortifies social ties. The fundamental idea is a wider feeling of *panlipunang gampanin* (social duty) that encompasses the community as well as personal thankfulness.

In Sikolohiyang Pilipino, utang na loob is understood as a multifaceted value that intertwines with emotional, social, and cultural dynamics. Unlike Western notions of gratitude, which are often associated with positive emotions, utang na loob can evoke complex feelings because it may create implicit social pressure to fulfill obligations even when it is difficult. As noted by Dancel (2005, 109–127), this value transcends mere thankfulness, becoming an integral part of the Filipino psyche that motivates prosocial behaviors, such as helping one’s family and community.

THE ELDEST CHILD AS WORKING PANGANAY

The role of the eldest child in Filipino families, often referred to as the *panganay*, carries significant responsibilities, especially in families with limited financial resources. This social dynamic is deeply embedded in the Filipino value system, where familial loyalty and interdependence are prioritized. Research has shown

that the panganay is frequently expected to take on a caregiving role for younger siblings, acting as a surrogate parent in many ways. Medina (2001) emphasizes that the panganay often assumes both caregiving and disciplinary duties, a responsibility driven by cultural expectations and the hierarchical nature of Filipino families. These expectations are more pronounced in lower-income families, where the financial contributions of the eldest child become crucial for the family's survival.

In addition to caregiving, the eldest child is also expected to contribute financially, sometimes at the expense of their ambitions. A study by Alampay and Jocson (2011) reveals that many Filipino panganays take on early employment to support their siblings' education, a practice driven by the collective orientation of Filipino families. Eldest children may sacrifice their own educational opportunities or career aspirations to prioritize the needs of their siblings and parents. The social pressure to conform to these familial roles is heightened by *utang na loob*. We have identified some gaps across different studies that tackle the same topic of interest, such as contrasting intergenerational perspectives. There is limited literature exploring how the experience of *utang na loob* varies across generations. The expectations placed on panganays in traditional Filipino families may differ significantly between older generations and those in contemporary settings. For instance, while Nagtalon-Ramos (2020) examined intergenerational experiences of *utang na loob* among Filipino American nurses, few studies have focused on this aspect within the Filipino family structure. Investigating these intergenerational differences could address a crucial gap in understanding how family expectations evolve over time.

Further, we acknowledge the rise of modern technology and the internet, which may also present a research gap. Brey (2006) highlights concerns that the internet poses risks to social structures, culture, and human relationships. As such, the widespread use of the internet and social media among younger generations has introduced new forms of communication that may affect how traditional values like *utang na loob* are understood. While older generations rely on face-to-face

interactions to uphold family expectations, younger generation panganays are exposed to diverse, often individualistic values online. This shift could influence how utang na loob is perceived and practiced.

2. RESEARCH OBJECTIVES AND FRAMEWORK

As observed in the existing literature, there has been a temporal gap wherein a lack of recent research has left a discontinuity in understanding this particular phenomenon, considering variations across intergenerational perspectives. This study thus sought to address this gap in the literature by acknowledging how utang na loob keeps pace with the latest perspectives of working panganays in the present generation through the use of narrative analysis.

The structure, content, and purpose of the stories people tell during socialization are the center of narrative psychology (Murray 2003). It acknowledges that we live in a world of stories and that we translate the stories we tell each other to understand the behavior of both ourselves and other people. We utilized Murray's (2000) framework as a guide to elicit three levels of narrative analysis: personal (experiences), positional (roles and responsibilities), and ideological (shared values and beliefs). Murray further argued that within the discipline of health psychology, narratives serve as crucial tools for making sense of illness, recovery, and coping. Through storytelling, individuals do not simply recount events but actively construct meaning, integrate disruptions caused by illness or trauma into their life stories, and preserve a sense of identity and coherence. This interpretive process highlights how health and well-being are shaped not only by biological or psychological factors but also by the meanings individuals assign to their lived experiences.

The personal level of analysis examined how working panganays perceive their personal experiences of utang na loob. The positional level of analysis examined how the narrative presents the working panganay's responsibilities and the roles assigned by family members. The social representations of

learned values in the narratives were examined at the ideological level of analysis.

Since working panganays have more responsibilities compared to their younger siblings in Filipino families, it is important to understand their perspective because these could influence how they carry themselves and manage multiple roles in the household. Specifically, we asked:

1. What personal experiences do working panganays have with utang na loob?
2. What positions are assigned to working panganays by their parents, siblings, and themselves?
3. What ideologies are reflected in the working panganays' narratives of their overall experience?

3. METHODS AND ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

This study examined the narratives of working panganays concerning the concept of utang na loob. Driven by the purpose of bringing together an “organized interpretation of a sequence of events” (Murray 2003, 113 cited in Willig 2008, 133), the study employed narrative analysis as a framework for the data analysis. We utilized a qualitative research design to construct broad interview questions to process thoroughly guided data collection. The study gathered data from eight individuals through purposive sampling. Participants are the eldest children in the family who have personal experience working to provide financial support for their family members. All participants reside in the Southern Philippines, with four female and four male respondents between the ages of 25 to 40 years old with current occupations as virtual assistant, *barangay kagawad* (councilor), marine engineer, guidance counselor, human resource professional, and health education and promotion officer, earning in the low income to upper middle income. The respondents hail from Surigao City, Zamboanga del Sur, Lanao del Sur, Misamis Oriental, and Cagayan de Oro City.

Semi-structured interviews were utilized with broad questions to allow the interviewees to construct their narratives.

These questions were validated by a senior member of the research team. Probing questions were used to further clarify responses. The interviews were recorded and transcribed verbatim with all identifying information removed. A total of seven (7) questions were constructed for the interview. These questions were aimed at asking the participant about their journey as a working panganay supporting the family [item 1]; their experiences as the panganay in the family and their responsibilities [item 2]; the expectations placed by parents and siblings [item 3]; their definition of utang na loob [item 4]; and the reflections, challenges, and insights gathered by the panganay based on their unique experiences [item 5, 6, and 7]. English, Cebuano, and Surigaonon translations were included in the interview guide to accommodate the participants' preferred language.

Online advertisements in the form of a “call for participants” post shared through social media platforms (i.e., Facebook) were used to gather the participants for this study. Before the virtual interview, participants were contacted and asked to sign the informed consent form that disclosed the nature and purpose of the study as well as the conditions of participation. “*Pakikipagkuwentuhan*” or storytelling was employed as an Indigenous research method to ground Filipino psychology within this study. This approach enabled researchers to engage with participants in a conversational manner that encouraged them to share personal narratives relevant to the study's focus, maintaining a culturally resonant and open dialogue (Orteza 1997). To ensure the online safety of both researchers and the participants, interviews were conducted via secure, encrypted video conferencing platforms. The audio recording of the interview sessions was transcribed and used only for data analysis. Furthermore, strict compliance with the Psychological Association of the Philippines (PAP) stipulation on research ethics was followed.

Thematic analysis following the analytical framework of Braun and Clarke (2014) was conducted by the researchers. Common patterns were extracted from the raw data and initial codes were developed. Following this, codes were organized

according to Murray’s (2000) theoretical framework as the potential themes that emerged from the narratives. The focus of analysis in the study was on the conceptualization of utang na loob as described by each participant and their personal experiences as working panganays. Further, the levels of analysis were interconnected, prompting a higher-level review from all authors to identify patterns across different levels. All excerpts quoted in this paper were translated into English.

4. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The following themes were elicited from the interviews: personal, positional, and ideological (see table 1). The themes were divided into three chapters (beginning, middle, and end) to highlight the unique experiences of the working panganays at different times of their life. The beginning chapter pertains to the early experiences of being aware of the identity and role of the panganay, which transitions to a middle chapter of additional responsibilities, reaching an end chapter of their present experiences as working panganays. Researchers noted existing connections across the themes.

Table 1. Themes Describing the Narratives of Working Panganays

Chapter	Personal	Positional	Ideological
Beginning: Being the Panganay	Experience of early maturity and filial pressure	Perceived role of parents as unable to fully provide the needs of the family	Internalized familial obligations shaped by cultural expectations
	Experience of gratitude for a collective effort toward an education	Perceived role of panganay as a second parent to younger siblings in child-rearing	
Middle: Dealing with negative major life events	Experience of stepping up from a family crisis	Perceived role of younger siblings as dependent on the panganay for guidance	Empowered responsibility arising from adversity to provide family support
End: Embracing the assumed role and responsibility	Experience of prioritizing family needs over personal interests	Perceived role of panganay as the primary financial provider for the family	Increased hope in the capacity to cultivate a better future for one's family
	Experience of fulfillment to give back out of love and will	Perceived role of panganay as an active decision-maker in the household	

4A. BEING THE PANGANAY

EXPERIENCE OF EARLY MATURITY AND FILIAL PRESSURE

In their early years, panganays have acknowledged their socioeconomic status to make certain adjustments in the guiding factors of their actions, particularly in the attainment of their respective goals. That is, their identity is shaped over time based on what is expected of their roles as the working panganay. Thus, they consider such experiences as their preparation for the later stage of being the eldest child as presented below:

“I was not a self-proclaimed breadwinner, but I could somehow say that I was being prepared slowly.”
(Participant 5)

“I am already aware of my status in life that I was not born into a well-off family.” (Participant 3)

Furthermore, panganays bear the filial pressure, which their parents and caregivers expect of them. This expectation leads to early maturity in terms of how they perceive the realities of life and their responsibility to the family. Resultingly, they were able to commit to an extension of responsibility, especially to their younger siblings.

EXPERIENCE OF GRATITUDE FOR A COLLECTIVE EFFORT TOWARD AN EDUCATION

In recollections of their early life, panganays viewed their experience of attaining an education from a rooted appreciation for the communal support provided by their immediate and extended family members. This gratitude goes beyond simple acknowledgment because they recognize their educational journey has been a collective effort. It involved sacrifices from parents and relatives who provided financial support.

“When I reached 4th year, from high school to college, it was my uncle, who is like my father, who sent me to college . . . So, they were the ones who paid for my education, and I am very thankful for them because they really supported me in my studies back then in college.” (Participant 2)

Through such gratitude, panganays acknowledged a profound duty to reciprocate the assistance they received by dedicating themselves to their studies and eventually stepping into the role of a provider for their families.

“Actually, those people who helped me—up until now—I make sure to gradually show my appreciation to them, so that I can give something back to them, even just a little because they helped me through really difficult times.” (Participant 1)

The narratives above illustrate how panganays frame family achievements as shared successes. Yet, this gratitude often transforms into an internalized obligation to give back, sometimes at the cost of their own personal aspirations. The analysis highlights how these conflicting thoughts, emotions, and actions coexist as gratitude for collective support in attaining an education and are inseparable from the sense of indebtedness to those who sacrificed for them. This coexistence reflects a narrative tension in which appreciation and burden are not opposing forces but intertwined dynamics that shape how panganays construct their identity and sense of purpose.

POSITIONING OF PARENTS AS UNABLE TO FULLY PROVIDE FOR THE NEEDS OF THE FAMILY

Even at a very young age, panganays have viewed their parents as unable to fully provide for the financial and emotional needs of the family. This prompted their belief to look for ways to sustain their own needs and their family's needs at an early age. This is manifested through the panganays' attempts to either look for scholarships to continue their education without inflicting

any form of financial burden on their parents or to look for jobs in order to provide for their families. This is particularly highlighted in the sentiments of Participant 1 and echoed in the statements of Participant 8 on her mother's journey as a single parent, respectively:

"If I were to go to college, they should not have to spend even a peso for me because we don't have money." (Participant 1)

"My mother is a single mom. So, I really wanted to help her because we are really struggling financially. So, my goal after I graduated was really [to] just start working, like start earning money for myself." (Participant 8)

POSITIONING AS PANGANAY WHO ACTS AS THE SECOND PARENT TO YOUNGER SIBLINGS IN CHILD-REARING

Panganays are always deemed as the responsible ones in the family even at an early age. They are expected to have learned to adopt a stance of preparedness for uncertainties, framing their hardships as grounds for taking up future responsibilities. This role that they play extends to their siblings. The parents of such panganays would turn over, if not, share the load of child-rearing responsibilities to the panganay as they amass more financial capabilities and resources. They would stand as the provider for their sibling's education and even their sibling's desires and wants. This is shown in the attempt of Participant 4 to spare some extra allowance for her sister:

"As a student, when I had extra [money], I would even give that to my sister because sometimes she has several requirements in her course. I would feel pity every time she will ask from our parents. So, if I had extra money or extra allowance, I would give it to her."

This common practice has shown stark differences among various socio-economic groups. For those in seemingly

middle-class households, panganays are willing to bear this responsibility. However, this shows a conflicting reaction in panganays in lower-income households whose families solely rely on them. They emit a more aggrieved reaction toward this responsibility because their help extends not only to their siblings but also to their own separate families. This is apparent in the statement of Participant 1:

“I have so many responsibilities to bear: my sibling, my younger sibling, and the newborn child of my younger sibling who is around 2 years old. So that’s why I have so many [financial] responsibilities to provide for diapers, milk, food, and wipes. So there’s a lot.”

INTERNALIZED FAMILIAL OBLIGATIONS SHAPED BY CULTURAL EXPECTATIONS IDEOLOGY

Filipino values and cultural expectations are inseparable from the pangalay’s view of themselves. Early in life, they have gained an awareness of the value of prioritizing their families’ needs above their own. This internalized ideology has shaped them to form an independent sense of self that is built on fulfilling the familial duties expected of them. Such duties have been reinforced by the pangalay’s own interactions with their parents or guardians. While other obligations may not have been stated explicitly, they feel that their parents have been rather implicit in other duties as mentioned by the participants.

“My mother always tells me and has instilled in me that a person who endures will become blessed.”
(Participant 1)

“I really feel that I have to give them something because they might feel bad.” (Participant 3)

Panganays also expressed their early experiences in embedding the cultural expectation of the need to build oneself to give back to their families. Such filial pressures as perceived by pangalanays

are narrated not just as burdens but rather as legitimizing forces that validate their identity:

“As the eldest child, you know, I have to really build myself up because, you know, a lot of people are relying on me.” (Participant 2)

“What I want isn’t the only thing that matters because I also have to think about how I can give back to them. I have to repay them.” (Participant 3)

Panganays construct their identities around the themes of early maturity, filial pressure, and the internalization of cultural expectations. Although these expectations are not necessarily expressed, they are, however, strengthened by cultural norms in the family. As such, shared values and beliefs can be felt and observed by panganays. Rooted in their early childhood experiences, they become aware of their socioeconomic status and prepare themselves to later assume the responsibility of being the family provider. Gratitude for communal support in education appears inseparable from their duty to give back but often comes at a personal cost. As gaps in parental support arise, panganays step into roles as providers and second parents, embodying Filipino values of *utang na loob* and sacrifice. In doing so, their sense of self is defined less by having autonomy in making decisions for themselves, but rather it is more about sharing the collective responsibilities within the family.

4B. DEALING WITH MAJOR LIFE EVENTS

EXPERIENCE OF STEPPING UP FROM A FAMILY CRISIS

Transitioning to the middle phase in life, panganays experienced a turning point when they stepped up from a family crisis. This has led to the immediate acceptance of additional tasks in the household, leaving them with no choice but to take on the responsibility as the panganay. Specifically, this was evident in

the event of a medical condition or death of a family member as mentioned below:

“The hospital could not handle it because my father’s tumor got bigger. So somehow, we were still confused as a family with what was happening. So the big finances, big projects or needs of the family, I was the one to provide for my father’s maintenance and everything . . . it changes you.” (Participant 5)

“When I lost my father—he died—I was in first year college at that time. When I realized that at that moment, I pondered on the weight of my responsibility as an eldest child because since then I was able to grasp my overall responsibility.” (Participant 6)

In many families, this experience compels the panganay to step into a more mature role, sometimes adopting responsibilities far beyond their years. They may need to support younger siblings emotionally, manage household tasks, or even help with financial concerns, placing them in a caretaker role that accelerates their maturity. This shift can instill resilience and a heightened sense of empathy as they become more attuned to the emotional needs of others. However, the weight of these new responsibilities can also bring emotional challenges, such as feeling overwhelmed due to the expectation of being “strong” for the family.

POSITIONING OF YOUNGER SIBLINGS WHO ARE DEPENDENT ON THE ELDEST CHILD FOR GUIDANCE

It is emphasized that panganays are thought to have a duty to nurture and mentor their younger siblings, especially in their middle chapter. They frequently talked about having a strong sense of duty to act as role models for their younger siblings, providing them with both practical and emotional support. This dependence strengthens their sense of responsibility and establishes their position as the family’s pillar of support.

For Participant 2, the pressure of being the panganay and the first to graduate college was significant because it positioned them as a model for the younger siblings:

“I was the one who graduated from college. I felt the pressure as someone who is the eldest [child] in the original family . . . many are also counting on me.”

This participant clearly felt the weight of responsibility as the panganay, recognizing that their success or failure directly influenced the expectations placed on them by their younger siblings. Similarly, panganays position themselves as a guide for their younger siblings to prioritize education as a pathway toward improving their lives as indicated by Participant 3:

“Sometimes, I just tell my younger sibling, ‘Focus on your studies. When you graduate and find a job, I’ll leave here.’”

EMPOWERED RESPONSIBILITY ARISING FROM ADVERSITY TO PROVIDE FAMILY SUPPORT IDEOLOGY

This theme emphasizes the sense of empowerment that working panganays experience as a result of their early adversity that was brought into the middle stage of life. They view their duty as a source of strength and moral obligation. They take pride in meeting family standards despite making major personal sacrifices. Their identification as the family’s cornerstone is strengthened by redefining their struggle of financial hardship, unfulfilled personal aspirations, or a lack of familial support as sources of resilience. Participant 2 pointed out that because of the need to care for the family, their primary emphasis is now meeting their role as the primary provider rather than pursuing personal financial gain:

“It’s pressure on me because when it comes to finances, I really feel like it’s time for me not only to purely think of my own financial situation.”

Despite the weight of the obligation, it is also incredibly empowering. Being able to provide for their families, even at the expense of personal sacrifice, is often a source of fulfillment and meaning for working panganays. For them, being able to provide, no matter the personal cost, is enough to make them happy. Family crises often compel panganays to step into adult roles early on, taking on the challenge of handling financial and emotional responsibilities that position them as both providers and role models. This burden can be heavy, but it also fosters resilience and empowerment as fulfilling family needs become a central source of meaning in their lives.

4C. EMBRACING THE ASSUMED ROLE AND RESPONSIBILITY

EXPERIENCE OF PRIORITIZING FAMILY NEEDS OVER PERSONAL INTERESTS

At present, panganays experience making sacrifices to prioritize the needs of the family over their personal interests, such as sending their siblings to school, taking care of their parents or grandparents, and overseeing the well-being of the entire family. These personal interests may be a preferred career, material possessions, or major life decisions. In some cases, this means having to delay moving out and getting married as indicated by the participants:

“I am not able to dream for myself like what I want because I should think that I must provide for them. I should pay them back . . . it’s like being tied. I want to live in big cities, but I cannot because I have my grandmother, my siblings.” (Participant 3)

““Let’s get married,”” he said. I won’t because I will finish sending my sister, who is in nursing, to school. So, I still said no the next time because I still have my third sibling. So up until my youngest sibling finished school, I really did not marry.” (Participant 4)

This experience can lead them to set aside hobbies, plans, or even career aspirations to support the family, developing a deep sense of duty. However, this responsibility can also bring challenges as they may feel a sense of loss over missed opportunities or a delayed pursuit of their goals.

EXPERIENCE OF FULFILLMENT TO GIVE BACK OUT OF LOVE AND WILL

Panganays reflected on their personal experiences in the present, describing a deep sense of fulfillment and satisfaction. This sense of fulfillment manifests in their ability to provide for themselves and their families. Despite the challenges faced throughout their journey, they continue to be fueled by pure love and a willingness to sustain their family's needs. Several panganays expressed this:

"You do something, and they ask for something in return. But if you do something because you love what you're doing, it's being selfless. You do it because you want your siblings to succeed, you want to honor your parents, and it has a sense of purpose." (Participant 4)

"It's just out of love, and it's like I don't want to see my family struggling. As much as I can, I'll give them what they need, what they want." (Participant 5)

"Being the responsible eldest sister role is really fulfilling because I've seen my worth. I can do everything. I can provide. I'm helping him [my brother] with what he wants because I didn't have that before." (Participant 8)

POSITIONING AS PANGANAY WHO IS THE PRIMARY FINANCIAL PROVIDER FOR THE FAMILY AND AN ACTIVE DECISION-MAKER IN THE HOUSEHOLD

Panganays now partake in the primary role as the financial provider for the family. At this level, they are working to sustain the overall needs of the family, which are paying for the bills, tuition fees, and medications, among others. This transitional

shift from early realizations of responsibility to becoming the primary financial provider becomes most evident once pangnanays begin working as reflected on by Participant 5:

“So now I’ve started being the breadwinner—I think around 2022, since I began working as a marine engineer on a ship. Almost all the big finances, major projects, or family needs—I’m the one providing. For my father’s maintenance and everything, I’m the one providing.”

It is also evident that there are struggles in balancing adult responsibilities while carrying additional responsibilities for family members as expressed by Participant 6:

“As an eldest [child], I really support [the family], like for the bills, for the food, for the transportation, and medicine for my mom.”

As soon as the pangnanay has provided financial support, they too assume the role of an active decision-maker in the household. Such a role is framed not solely based on obligation but also as fulfilling and affirming their worth. For them, this is an indication of their growth and significance in the family. They can take charge of managing funds, giving advice, and solving problems. This is expressed by Participant 2:

“I am happy now that at the age of 28, I am already one of the decision-makers. Especially with my mother, I am one of the [people] who makes decisions in the family. Even on my father’s side, my opinion already matters, which means that I really grew as a person unlike before when I would only follow them. Whatever the decision, I should be one [of the people] to contribute to making decisions.”

INCREASED HOPE IN THE CAPACITY TO CULTIVATE A BETTER FUTURE FOR ONE’S FAMILY IDEOLOGY

With early realizations of reality and the shift to their present state as adults, pangnanays often act instead of react. They aim to give support in whatever means they can to help their families.

In this sense, they want to rely on themselves and their own capabilities to reduce their parents' hardships and to also add comfort to their own lives. Panganays view this sacrifice out of love and duty for the family, although this is also tied to their own views of *utang na loob* to their relatives who have helped them. This is heavily highlighted in the following responses:

"It feels like pressure to me in the sense that I have a lot of debt to the people who helped me and that I carry that [debt] until now in a way that I should help [them] back, to my father's siblings, to my mother's siblings. So the [list] of people that I need to help is broad. That is why I need to step up my game because it is not easy to carry every day that I have to pay that debt of gratitude to these people because they spent a lot on me." (Participant 2)

"Typically, as they say, it is a toxic Filipino mentality that you have to pay them back, which is actually true. But at the end of the day, you really get soft, especially if they are still your family member." (Participant 5)

Such tensions experienced by panganays often lead them to adopt a strong mindset of preparing for the future and finding ways to ease the mental load of balancing finances.

"In the financial aspect, I always set aside emergency funds and always think ahead, proactive. And I think because of those challenges I faced, I always think or plan ahead, as if I were also the head of the family—it has become like that." (Participant 5)

In the present stage, panganays position themselves as primary providers who consistently prioritize family needs over personal aspirations. This role, though marked by sacrifice, is also reframed as fulfilling, affirming their identity and moral worth. By assuming financial responsibility and decision-making authority, they transform obligation into resilience, sustaining an ideology of hope that legitimizes continued self-denial in pursuit of a better future for their families.

The narratives of the study share a commonality in their conceptualization of *utang na loob* as manifested in a meaningful sense of “returning the sacrifices and favors out of the goodness of their heart” that have been granted to them by their families. In this study, we explored the personal experiences, positions, and ideologies of the working *panganays* to gauge their collective perceptions of the said Filipino psychological construct. Themes across the narratives included immense gratitude, feelings of love, and a strengthened will to reciprocate the hardships their families have gone through to help them achieve their goals (i.e., completing their education). *Panganays* feel a deep sense of fulfillment and satisfaction in reaching a stage where they are capable of providing more for their families. However, while one cannot fully eradicate the existing social pressures to conform to one’s moral obligation in taking the familial role as a primary provider (Alampay and Jocson 2011; Rungduin et al. 2016), the *panganays* of this study rooted their perceptions of *utang na loob* in one’s personal desire and commitment to give back. As such, the discoveries collated from the narratives promoted one’s willingness and one’s intrinsic desire for the ability as a ‘provider’, which allows them to gain fulfillment from supporting the younger siblings and other members of their families (Zajonc 1976).

The results indicate that working *panganays* engage in self-reflection on their past personal experiences that have shaped their current being. The recognition of such experiences has granted them both gratitude and the ability to reflect on the steps they need to take to repay their respective families. A number of the participants, when asked about their concept of *utang na loob*, mention this as a selfless form of providing for their families. Although not removing the concept from its original meaning in Filipino psychology (Enriquez 1994; Kaut 1961), many *panganays* view their support as an act of altruism and self-sacrifice. This perspective reflects a deep commitment to one’s familial well-being, where personal desires take secondary priority to achieving the family’s collective needs. A key point for these working *panganays* is the belief in a sense of duty to provide for their families. Similar to the ideology of Rungduin

et al. (2016) on utang na loob, panganays view their ability to give back as stemming from a social duty to reciprocate for the beneficiaries despite not specifically requesting reimbursement. Thus, working panganays have embraced this responsibility without any regret, viewing their support as a heartfelt way to express love and profound gratitude for the sacrifices made to help them reach their goals.

Furthermore, there are important insights into the implications of utang na loob in Filipino family dynamics that demonstrate its significant influence on the duties and responsibilities of working panganays in the Southern Philippines. Panganays are positioned as both providers and caregivers due to their internalization of familial responsibilities, which are influenced by cultural norms. Reiterating studies on how utang na loob can impede personal goals when family expectations become excessively demanding, this can lead to substantial psychological and financial stress, even while it generates strong intergenerational support (Dizon et al. 2024; Rungduin et al. 2016).

Utang na loob has changed in contemporary settings to represent the conflict between the past collectivist beliefs and the emergence of individualistic desires among newer generations. Panganays are moving toward “enlightened loyalty,” where reciprocation is based on voluntary caring rather than guilt-driven obligation, as a result of urbanization and social media exposure (Gohu 2022). This change promotes striking a balance between upholding family obligations and achieving individual objectives. However, putting family needs first frequently prevents panganays from moving up the social ladder because opportunities and money are diverted to family responsibilities, which maintains socioeconomic disparities (Lagon 2024).

Based on the narratives, families may change how utang na loob is used by redefining it as an act of love and respect rather than a heavy debt. Panganays might feel less psychologically burdened by such a viewpoint, enabling them to accept their duties with satisfaction rather than bitterness (Dancel 2005). Filipino families, then, can modify utang na loob to contemporary situations while maintaining its cultural integrity by encouraging voluntary cooperation and respect for one another.

Interventions in the community and policy are necessary to address the issues that eldest children face. Programs that emphasize career development, financial literacy, and mental health assistance can give eldest children the tools they need to carry out their responsibilities well. Campaigns for public awareness might also inform families about the advantages of sharing responsibilities fairly, which would lessen the psychological and socioeconomic strains associated with *utang na loob*. Filipino families may ensure that everyone's well-being is attained without compromising personal goals by placing this cultural value inside modern frameworks.

5. LIMITATIONS AND CONCLUSION

This study highlights the deeply ingrained cultural concept of *utang na loob* and how it significantly affects the lives of working pangnanays in the Southern Philippines. Results show how pangnanays internalize their roles as caregivers and providers, motivated by a deep sense of obligation to return the sacrifices made by their families as well as by a great deal of love and gratitude. Many pangnanays accept their obligations as acts of selflessness and personal fulfillment despite the difficulties presented by societal and familial expectations. This reflects a balance between traditional values and growing individualistic viewpoints.

The narratives reflect how *utang na loob* is changing in contemporary Filipino society, where ideas of “enlightened loyalty” promote sincere and choice reciprocation rather than duty. Nonetheless, the strain of family obligations frequently restricts chances for individual development and intensifies socioeconomic disparities. Families can lessen psychological strain and create a more positive dynamic that promotes both individual and group well-being by redefining *utang na loob* as a shared act of love and respect.

It is essential to encourage family cooperation and shared responsibility to adapt *utang na loob* to modern situations. This will create a culture in which help is provided freely and fairly. Furthermore, pangnanays can better manage their dual roles

if policy and community actions address the emotional and financial difficulties they encounter. Future studies that include a wider range of socioeconomic and cultural backgrounds will improve our knowledge of this deeply rooted Filipino value and ensure it keeps fostering family ties without impeding personal development. Considerations for incorporating mixed method approaches along with ethnographic methodological tools can provide a more comprehensive understanding of any emerging patterns. This study also extends recommendations to consider broader contexts, mixed methods, and practical interventions for future studies.

A limitation of the study was the saturation of the participants in certain parts of Southern Philippines (i.e., Mindanao), and data may not represent the perspectives of panganays in the entire area. It might be essential to add more participants from different places in Mindanao to have more diverse and rich information on this topic with the same population. Moreover, further studies may explore insights into utang na loob in panganays with different socio-economic backgrounds and contrasting views of urban-born individuals and those who were raised in rural areas. This might answer the limitation on contradicting experiences and viewpoints of utang na loob in panganays since varying family dynamics are deeply rooted in one's culture.

TABLE

1 Themes Describing the Narratives of Working Panganays

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